

Maudie



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Maude

Amuse Bouche

Yellowfin tuna tostada swirled with tomatillo, passionfruit and Thai chili aioli
Trout Pai Tee with trout roe and smoked trout, avocado mousse and fermented Fresno pepper gel, and lime zest on top
Bao of smoked eggplant purée, golden sesame aioli, and nasturtium leaf

Mendoza Family Farm Chayote

Tsar Nicoulai Kaluga caviar, chayote sautéed in brown butter, salsa verde, and lemon zest

Santa Barbara Spiny Lobster

Salted Persian cucumber, buddha's hand, *aguachile rojo* sauce of *chile de árbol* and *guajillo*
Serve with a lobster-shaped cracker with lobster head aioli, dill, and lime zest

Ranched Purple Sea Urchin

Codium fragile sabayon, white sturgeon caviar, satsuma mandarin, and wakame flakes

The Cultured Red Abalone

Abalone from The Cultured Abalone Farm, with its liver sauce and *Manchamanteles* mole sauce
Pair with Weiser family farm cone cabbage and pickled Asian pear

House Made Bread and Butter

Brioche bread with oregano, chive, and thyme
Cultured butter aged for ten weeks

Line-Caught Black Cod

Salsa negra made with the ash of *chile morita*, coco beans, Asari clams, sea asparagus, agretti, and iceplant

Wolfe Ranch Quail

Bread crumbs, maui onion, soubise, red wine achiote sauce

Point Reyes Blue Cheese

Buñuelo doughnut, honey, blue cheese, shaved macadamia

JJ's Lone Daughter Ranch

Hachiya persimmon, puréed and segmented, served with finger lime, chili powder, and Moroccan mint

Laubacher's Musquée de Provence

Piloncillo and white chocolate ganache, caramelized Musquée de Provence pumpkin filling
Caramelized milk gelato, maple leaves made with pumpkin, pumpkin seed oil powder

Windrose Farm Arkansas Black Apples

A sphere of cocoa nibs, mole espuma, *corico sinaloense* cookies, apple purée, and salted caramel
Almond sponge cake and salted-caramelized apple

Mignardises

Dark chocolate and morita chili bonbon
Sesame and guava macaron
Medjool dates cream puff





Amuse Bouche

NV Bricoleur Vineyards, “Flying by the Seat of Our Pants,” North Coast, California

Mendoza Family Farm Chayote

2021 Savage Grace, Grüner Veltliner, "Underwood Mountain Vineyard," Columbia Gorge, Washington

Santa Barbara Spiny Lobster

Momokawa, Organic Junmai Ginjo Sake, Oregon

Ranched Purple Sea Urchin

2022 Jolie-Laide Trousseau Gris, “Fanucchi-Wood Road,” Sonoma County, California

The Cultured Red Abalone

2014 Terre Rouge, Roussanne, Monarch Mine Vineyard, Sierra Foothills, California

House Made Bread and Butter

Line-Caught Black Cod

2021 Leah Jørgensen, “Tour Rain,” Cabernet Franc and Gamay Noir, Oregon

Wolfe Ranch Quail

2013 Soliste, “Out of the Shadows,” Syrah, Bennett Valley, California

Point Reyes Blue Cheese

2021 J. Lohr, Late Harvest Riesling, Arroyo Seco, Monterey, California

JJ’s Lone Daughter Ranch

Laubacher’s Musquée de Provence

2018 Dashe, “Lily Hill Vineyard,” Late Harvest Zinfandel, Dry Creek Valley, California

Windrose Farm Arkansas Black Apples

Mignardises

2018 Babcock Winery, “Once in a Lifetime,” Ultra Late Harvest Viognier, Santa Barbara County, California

2015 Château Soucherie, Premier Cru Chaume, Coteaux du Layon



Los Angeles rarely experiences rain, but when it does, a sense of nostalgia blankets the city. This sentimental atmosphere leads us to a cherished haven known as Maude, nestled on Beverly Drive. Unassumingly positioned, Maude may escape notice when casually strolling by, its discreet allure revealed only upon spotting the subtle M logo. As we open the door, we're greeted by a diminutive dining room housing no more than ten tables. Our reservation guides us to the counter—a remarkably petite yet remarkably snug space. Sporting a mere four seats, this explains the challenge of securing a reservation. From our vantage point, we enjoy an unparalleled view, observing every nuance in the bustling kitchen. Directly before us, a photograph captures Granny Maude, Chef Curtis' grandmother, on her wedding day. Overhead, a shelf gracefully displays an array of vintage dinnerware. Immersed in the artful decor, we surrender to the enchantment of this intimate setting. The initial tinge of wistfulness evolves into boundless warmth and eager anticipation.



With a swift yet warm greeting from the team, the degustation journey promptly commences. Before us, a trio of amuse-bouche unfolds, revealing a harmonious blend of cultural influences. The initial offering, a tostada, takes center stage on the glass platform, featuring an exquisite "rose" of yellowfin tuna and tomatillo. Chef Osiel Gastelum's Mexican heritage is loudly pronounced through this amuse-bouche of tostada that uses tomatillo as the central element, an indigenous ingredient of Mexico and Central America. The tomatillo's tangy and citrusy notes intertwine with the lean yellowfin tuna, resulting in a delicate The addition of passionfruit and Thai chili aioli fails to contribute much, their impact is minimal. A mere drizzle of extra virgin olive oil and a pinch of salt would elevate the tostada to perfection.



As we linger in the aftermath of the disheartening first bite of Tostada, a culinary tsunami arrives from Southeast Asia in the form of Pai Tee, delivering a voluptuous texture and a gustatory impact. With each mouthful, a profound smokiness and the concentrated trout essence permeate the palate. Acting as a lubricant from Latin America, the avocado mousse and fermented Fresno pepper gel seamlessly enrich this medley with a silky texture, akin to a vibrant oil painting. The nutty and trout-like flavor of avocado, coupled with hints of fruitiness from the Fresno pepper, creates a sensational symphony of flavors that harmonizes perfectly with the smoked trout. The stark contrast between the buttery, velvety texture of avocado and the explosion of trout roe added an exhilarating dynamism to the overall experience.



The gustatory waves are soon quelled by a magical Bao. Hailing from Asia once again, this time from East Asia, this seemingly ordinary bao conceals immense energy within. In this all-embracing bite, the smoked eggplant purée and golden sesame aioli filling the bao provide an unprecedented satisfying sensation. Although equally rich, this Bao is no longer a riot of colors; instead, it exudes profound elegance, resembling a meticulous carving artwork with a single sandalwood as its foundation. The smoked eggplant purée, perhaps a pseudo-meat dish or simply an ode to the eggplant itself, displays remarkable depth and umami, while the sesame aioli further elevates the eggplant with its nutty toasty notes. The bao, much like its shape, presents a rounded, profound, and elegant gustatory aesthetics. The only drawback might be the bun's texture. Amidst the sensory delight, one couldn't help but notice the mushiness and stickiness.



NV Bricoleur Vineyards, “Flying by the Seat of Our Pants,” North Coast, California

Vineyard: Bricoleur Vineyards

Appellation: California Northern Coast

Aging: Stainless Steel Barrels

Dosage: 0.8% Dose using Reserve Chardonnay

Production: 247 Cases

Composition: 63% Chardonnay, 34% Pinot Noir 2% Reserve Wines 1% Pinot Meunier

When ordering the wine pairing, I was determined to step out of my comfort zone by escaping France and giving American wines a try. Hilarious enough, the first glass on the wine list that serves exclusively the West Coast wines of the United States, seems to be making an effort to bring me back to Champagne, France. The wine’s cuvée name, "Flying by the seat of our pants," appears to tell a story of making decisions based on intuition, while the winery's French name, Bricoleur, signifies the act of building something with no clear plan. While uncertain about the extent of this deliberately emphasized intuition in the winemaking process of this bottle, all signs indicate that the winemaker is determined to replicate Champagne on this North Coast land.

With a somewhat ordinary yet classic ratio of white and black fruits, the winemaker seems to favor the bright aroma and buttery texture of Chardonnay while hoping for Pinot Noir to bring a certain depth and elegance to the overall profile. Nonetheless, American-grown Chardonnay per se differs from its French counterpart. Climate variations, soil differences, and subtle variations in vines make American Chardonnay noticeably more overtly tawdry, showcasing flamboyant aromas to the fullest extent here. The glass is filled with the scent of a patisserie: a buttery pastry aroma reminiscent of financier cake blends with candied citrus zest, rich honey fragrances, and ripe fruit notes. On the palate, the presence of Pinot Noir does bring a certain depth, but what I sense more is a singular direction of ripeness – almost overly so. A pronounced over-oxidized flavor in the glass raises my eyebrows, leaving me wondering whether it's the winemaker's pursuit of maturity or perhaps an issue related to the restaurant, causing the wine to undergo excessive oxidation. I am inclined to believe the latter. As for minerality and a more complex texture, I have yet to experience them in this young American wine. It seems that emulating Champagne is no easy task – the road ahead is long and the journey far from completion!



Mexican cuisine often evokes a sense of vibrant warmth, yet in this caviar dish, such elements unfold with an unexpectedly refreshing touch across the canvas. The black marble counter, transparent glass platter – a breath of freshness seems palpable. Zooming in, pear-shaped cuts of chayote, arranged into a floral circle, surround a quenelle of caviar. Beneath the caviar lies an exceptionally refreshing and light-textured salsa verde. Treading the path of freshness, savoring this caviar dish is akin to embarking on a journey through a Nordic forest. While salsa verde and chayote are both considered Mexican elements, the non-spicy, green-notes-filled salsa verde and the nearly pristine chayote evoke memories of my time at Aska in New York years ago – a time when the caviar dish was equally fresh and invigorating. Whether by design or happenstance, this dish unveils the versatility of Mexican cuisine and ingredients to a global audience. In a country renowned for its obsession with spice, the ingredients, born in such a vibrant land, are presented in their purest and freshest form. It manifests a deep respect for ingredients, paying homage to the essence of nature at its finest. For discerning epicureans, this dish is destined to evoke a sense of awe.





2021 Savage Grace, Grüner Veltliner, “Underwood Mountain Vineyard,” Columbia Gorge, Washington

Varietal: Grüner Veltliner

Location: Western edge of the Columbia Gorge AVA (cooler)

Vinification: mixed skin-contact and whole-cluster pressed,
100% natural fermentation and unfiltered.

Wine Enthusiast: 93/100

Grüner Veltliner, Austria's most important grape variety in winemaking, is renowned for its crisp acidity and light-bodied nature, carrying a bouquet reminiscent of fresh orchards, nuanced with flavors of cooked vegetables like asparagus and white pepper. Its distinctive signature, however, lies in the discernible flint fragrance.

Pouring into the second glass, a 2021 Grüner Veltliner from winery Savage Grace. Sommelier Jessica Taylor escorts me to the Underwood Mountains Vineyard to witness a representation of Grüner Veltliner from the New World. Hailing from the land claimed by Savage Grace, one of the pioneering wineries in the youthful and ever-experimental Columbia Gorge wine region, this vineyard stretches along the western edge of the Columbia Gorge. While the Columbia Gorge may be relatively young in its viticultural history, the soil it sits upon is ancient, fostering various mesoclimates that coexist magically, creating a region of remarkable versatility. The western part of the Columbia Gorge experiences cooler and wetter conditions compared to its eastern counterpart. Acting as a natural funnel, the gorge ushers in cool air from the Pacific, replacing the hot desert air. This consistent airflow ensures a more stable temperature throughout the year. In terms of water content, the land benefits from protection against excessive rainfall, thanks to Mount Hood and Mount Adams, while simultaneously reaping the advantages of silty loam soil that is moderately drained, an ideal condition for advanced viticulture.

In the glass, a vibrant and linear Grüner Veltliner reveals itself with a pale yellow hue. Aromas waft from the glass, presenting a bouquet of matured bright floral fruit with hints of apricot-ish honey. This is complemented by additional notes of cooked tomato, grilled lemon, fennel, and white pepper. The soil, shaped by volcanic activity centuries ago, imparts a gorgeous flint fragrance to the wine.





Ensuing the refreshing breeze, a vibrant heatwave seems inevitable. Up next is a dish we've been observing since our arrival. In a repetitive motion, the chef grabs the lobster crisps from the oven before us, piping them with lobster brain aioli. On a separate plate, he arranges raw lobster meat in a round mold, then adorns the flesh with Buddha's hand zest. Further complementing the dish are the pickled Persian cucumbers and delicately garnished Borage flowers. Now, the culmination of this creation is unveiled before us. The server finishes the dish with a bath of aguachile rojo sauce crafted from chile de árbol and guajillo, bringing the entire composition to a fulfilled coda.

If the preceding dish already evoked memories of Aska, then this one, both in presentation and design, further recalls the Langoustine dish at Aska. Unlike the freshness reminiscent of Aska in the previous course, this lobster, with its ice-crystal core, is embraced by flames. A delightful interplay of ice and fire, a redefined chaud-froid. The lobster sashimi's immaculate ice-crystal flesh, paired with the crispy, succulent Persian cucumbers, is enrobed in the fiery aguachile rojo. This red sauce encapsulates the essence of two peppers – the chile de árbol introduces subtle spiciness with hints of nuttiness and smokiness, complemented by a light grassy undertone, while the guajillo contributes a sweet, fruity, tangy, smoky flavor profile, enriched with notes of berries and tea.



Neighboring the main dish is a side dish of lobster crisp accompanied by lobster brain aioli. Familiar garnishes such as lemon zest and dill persist in enhancing the aesthetics. Just like the moon gracefully orbiting the earth, the lobster crisp, with its abundant umami, provides a delightful sensory experience enveloping the center of the lobster crudo. The crisp itself appears to bear hints of lobster shell, but when enjoyed independently, it lacks the distinct flavor of lobster bisque. In contrast, the lobster brain aioli unfolds with intense umami and refined depth, reminiscent of a sophisticated elixir distilled from a pot of lobster bisque.



Momokawa, Organic Junmai Ginjo Sake, Oregon

Style: Junmai Ginjo

Milling: 58%

Rice: California Calrose

Yeast: Proprietary

Pressing: Yabuta Method

After the Grüner Veltliner, a specialized glass for Sauternes sweet wine is presented on the table. I am curious about the wine that will be poured into it when the sommelier arrives with a bottle of sake. Sake itself is not unexpected; nowadays, wine pairings often feature a glass of sake, a trend I observed as early as 2018 at the traditionally conservative Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare in New York. What catches my attention is that this sake is crafted right here in the United States. This particular sake is made using Calrose, a medium-grain rice variety native to California and notable as the founding variety of the California rice industry.

Common premium Japanese sake often utilizes rice varieties such as Yamada Nishiki, distinct from the everyday utility rice. Sake rice typically features a central white and semi-transparent outer structure. This is because the starch in the rice grains concentrates in the center of the sake rice kernel, while the outer layer consists of fat and protein. In contrast, regular rice has a more even distribution of fat, protein, and starch, resulting in a more uniform color of the rice grains. The structure of sake rice is crucial because the production of sake requires the central starch, while fat and protein need to be removed. I am unsure if California's Calrose rice is the most suitable choice for brewing sake, but it does have a higher starch ratio. Although this sake uses California rice, it is actually produced in Oregon. The sake does not provide detailed information about the water used, so it remains unknown whether the style of Oregon's local water has an impact on the sake's flavor. However, I lean towards believing it does not, as this sake is relatively affordable and seems more like an experiment conducted by the American progressives within the country, rather than a pursuit of the flavors that California rice and Oregon water sources could impart to sake.

Milled to 58%, this sake presents a refreshing and lively fruitiness, making it straightforward and easy to drink. In the glass, there are fresh citrus notes and a hint of pineapple, with no prominent floral aromas. Perhaps due to the use of Calrose, even with over 40% of the outer shell removed, the interior still retains a significant amount of fat and protein, resulting in a slightly cloudy rice flavor in the sake. Overall, it is approachable but lacks the ability to leave a lasting impression.



In the delicate aperitif glass, a culinary interlude unfolds, revealing a masterpiece of the ocean. Sea urchins, elegantly presented in a petite display, luxuriate in a frothy bath of seaweed sabayon crafted from codium fragile, an alga known poetically as Dead Man's Fingers. This harmonious symphony is elevated with accents of white sturgeon caviar, satsuma mandarin, and delicate wakame flakes. Our server proudly imparts the ecological significance, emphasizing that this particular purple urchin is considered invasive, making the act of consumption a supportive gesture towards the ecosystem. Cultivated to maturity in the farm after harvesting, the sea urchin may not match the rich creaminess and umami of those from Hokkaido or Santa Barbara. However, salvation comes in the form of the seaweed sabayon, stealing the spotlight and captivating the palate with its hypnotic and refined sensation, intensifying the oceanic umami and depth. Satsuma mandarin gracefully joins the medley, infusing it with a bright aroma and intricate complexity that lingers through the extended finish.



2022 Jolie-Laide Trousseau Gris, “Fanucchi-Wood Road,” Sonoma County, California

Region: Russian River Valley, Sonoma County.

Vineyard: Fanucchi-Wood Road

Vinification: short amount of skin contact, 6 month maturation in neutral barrels

Trousseau gris, a rather unfamiliar vocabulary for me. Drinking a wine made from a grape variety for the first time can be challenging, as one loses reference points and has no anticipation for what might happen. While having no prior experience with this wine, its characteristics are fortunately quite apparent. The wine presents itself as a delicately pure and elegant beauty, akin to a gracefully blossoming young girl. It exhibits an almost faint pink hue in the glass, accompanied by an exceptionally refined aroma profile. Not leaning towards sweetness, it unfolds the subtle sweetness of fresh Japanese melon, the floral fragrance of white flowers, and the freshness of white tea, all while leaving a hint of rose in its lingering fragrance. On the mouth, it is delicate and crisp, with a restrained expression of acidity. I am deeply impressed by its texture, especially the elegant fragrance of white tea and the brisk touch of delicate roses. This was later confirmed as I researched further, where its short duration of skin contact provides a touch of texture and imparts a light rosy hue to the wine.

Native to Jura, the Trousseau gris, a light-skinned mutation of the dark Trousseau grape variety, is a rare gem in the world of viticulture. Occasionally found in eastern France, it once flourished in California under the name Gray Riesling. However, its plantation dropped sharply in the 1980s, leaving only a ten-acre block at the Fanucchi Wood Road Vineyard in the Russian River Valley AVA as a testament to its presence. Nestled on Wood Road in the Russian River Valley, the Fanucchi Wood Road Vineyard stands as the sole home to Trousseau gris plantings in California, and quite possibly the entire United States. In a curious twist, during the 1970s, the grape gained popularity under the misnomer Gray Riesling. Considered a distinguished variety in the States, the Trousseau gris caught the attention of Peter Fanucchi and his father Arcangelo. Accidentally discovering a few Trousseau gris vines via a genetic test, they planted a ten-acre block in 1981 within this 90-year-old vineyard, among the Zinfandel vines.



The ode to the ocean continues, unveiling an unconventional abalone dish. Embraced by two distinctive sauces, the abalone becomes a canvas where the lively Mexican spiciness dances harmoniously with the refined umami notes from Japanese inspiration. The chef, drawing from Japanese culinary finesse, concocts a sauce using the abalone's liver, unlocking the ingredient's full potential in a precious elixir of umami. Meanwhile, the Manchamanteles Mole Sauce, a homage to the chef's roots, adds layers of flavor with its medley of assorted meat, chili peppers, vegetables, and fruits. While these sauces create a powerful blend of aromas, they somewhat overshadow the true essence of the abalone. Petite in size, the abalone lacks the expected resilient and bouncy texture. While undoubtedly cooked to extreme tenderness, this tenderness feels like a somewhat insincere attempt to compensate for the unattainable texture. Accompanying the abalone is a Weiser family farm cone cabbage, revealing wild scorch marks. The rustic allure is adorned with microgreens, edible flowers, and pickled Asian pears meticulously cut into triangular shapes. The cone cabbage, consistently mild with exceptional sweetness, adds delightful freshness and crunchiness to the palate. The Asian pears contribute a bright, sweet acidity akin to a salad dressing. When enjoyed together, the stark interplay between the refreshing aroma and crunchy texture of the cabbage and the opulent richness of the abalone forms a captivating masterpiece that radiates excitement, much like the energy of radiation.



2014 Terre Rouge, Roussanne, Monarch Mine Vineyard, Sierra Foothills, California

Release Date: February 2021

Viticulture: Planted with a clone of the Roussanne grape that originates from a Chave family parcel on the hill at Hermitage.

Vinification: Fermented in barrel and aged on lees.

Aged in bottle for two years prior to release.

Wine Enthusiast: 94/100

Presented in a Montrachet glass with a brilliantly golden hue, the next wine surprises me with an intriguing aroma profile I've never encountered before. Bursting forth like an explosion, it unveils a flamboyant sweetness and a robustly oxidized fragrance that permeates my senses, reaching into every cell. The lush sweetness reveals mature and sophisticated characteristics, reminiscent of aged honey, beeswax, and marzipan. Additionally, there's a toasted element, akin to caramelized popcorn, brioche, and sesame.

Initially, the aroma is complex and somewhat unapproachable, even displaying a touch of unfriendliness. However, with a brief period of rest in the glass, it undergoes a transformation, revealing an even stronger oxidation flavor— an intentional and deliberate aspect of the wine maker.

Upon tasting, the wine unfolds with a relatively neutral character. It boasts a medium body with mild acidity, yet it captivates with a splendid sense of minerality. The influence of lees aging and barrel fermentation contributes to its silky texture, offering a rich umami experience on the palate.



My curiosity seems to have caught the attention of the head chef. He approaches me with a friendly greeting and personally explains the utilization of some ingredients. Subsequently, he presents their homemade brioche and butter in front of us. The bread is hand-braided, incorporating oregano, chive, and thyme herbs. As for the cultured butter, it is crafted to European standards and aged for 10 weeks, imparting the butter with a nearly cheese-like depth and fragrance. The butter is evidently a success, its profound flavor immediately captivating me, making it enjoyable even when savored on its own. However, the bread seems somewhat lacking. Its texture is overly rustic, neither withholding the delicate softness of a French baguette nor embodying the robust wildness of an artisan sourdough. It is simply coarse and lacks sufficient moisture, resulting in a dry texture in the mouth. The fragrance of the herbs is also unconvincing. Perhaps incorporating them into the butter would be more effective.



In eager anticipation, we embrace the arrival of the first main course, featuring a meticulously seared sea cod. Presented on a sophisticated European classical plate, the fish is surrounded by a medley of accompaniments—clam, cocoa beans, shiso blossom, and a trio of oceanic greens. At the heart of this culinary masterpiece lay the essential Salsa negra crafted from chili morita ash. The cod itself is cooked with high standard, tender, and succulent, with a delightful surprise of crispiness in its skin. Kissed by the fire, the outer layer bears a gentle char from charcoal, imparting a beautiful crunchiness and an enchanting smoky aroma reminiscent of a primal jungle barbecue by the river bank. While the fish still retains a subtle fishiness, inherently unavoidable yet mildly displeasing, the chef's artistic touch extends to creating a microscopic marine ecosystem around the dish. It seems as if the chef aims to recreate the serene scene of the cod navigating the sea. The Asari clam contributes a tender yet bouncy texture, while the trio of sea vegetables—sea asparagus, agretti, and iceplant—offers a refreshing and succulent contrast. The black coco beans, resembling underwater rocks, present a creamy, delicate taste with a robust, chocolate-like flavor. Bringing all these elements together, the soulful sauce performs its culinary alchemy. The chile Morita, having endured prolonged exposure to high temperatures in the oven, transforms into ashes. Yet, from these embers, it is resurrected into a sauce infused with the mystical essence of ash, unveiling a mesmerizing depth of sweetness.





2021 Leah Jørgensen, “Tour Rain,” Cabernet Franc and Gamay Noir, Oregon

Composition: 45% Gamay and 55% Cabernet Franc

Vineyards: Cabernet Franc from Mae’s Vineyard - in Applegate Valle Southern Oregon
Gamay from Havlin Vineyard - Willamette Valley’s Van Duzer Corridor
in the Perrydale Hills.

Vinification: The Cabernet Franc went through traditional short vating (5-6 days), and was sorted, de-stemmed, crushed lightly (half whole berry, half crushed), with a four-day cold soak, starting fermentation at 55° F so as to have a slow, extended fermentation, with manual punch-downs twice daily during fermentation. It was aged in French oak barrels. Malolactic fermentation completed in two months. The Gamay was sorted, de-stemmed, whole berry crushed, with a four-day cold soak followed by manual punch-downs twice daily during fermentation, then aged in neutral French oak for 7 months, with malolactic fermentation completed in two months. The wine was racked, blended, then filtered prior to bottling.

As the sommelier presents the next glass of red wine, a sense of caution immediately sets in. Knowing that the upcoming course would feature fish and that pairing it with red wine is decidedly unconventional, I can’t help but be wary. Yet, in the current era of bold culinary experimentation, exemplified by the successful pairing of elegant Pinot Noir from Burgundy with sushi, I remain open to surprises.

The wine presented is a blend of Cabernet Franc and Gamay Noir from Oregon. My confidence in Gamay is well-founded; with its very low tannins, it is a delicate and lean red grape variety. In contrast, Cabernet Franc tends to have higher tannin levels. The aromas emanating from the wine glass exude a masculine quality, dominated by the inevitable presence of black fruit. Co-dominating notes of cigar box and green pepper heighten my concerns about how the wine would unfold on the palate. To my surprise, upon tasting, the wine reveals an exceptional suppleness. The tannins are barely noticeable, and both the acidity and viscosity exhibit remarkable subtlety. Rather than interfering with the fish's texture, the wine adds a certain depth of elegant fragrance, enhancing the overall experience of the fish dish.



The culmination of the dining experience arrives with the final savory course, and true to expectations, this dish proves to be a delight. Mexican cuisine exhibits a fervent passion for grilling, and the alluring aroma of charcoal grilling has always been irresistible. In this main course, the chef skillfully captures the robust smokiness reminiscent of wild flavors found in Mexican street food, particularly from a taco truck. Nestled at the center of the plate is half a gamey quail, charming yet untamed, adorned with evident traces of charcoal grilling and air-drying. Diverging from the presentation style of many refined French haute cuisine establishments, which often showcase small birds like quail or pigeon with either the legs or a center cut of the breast, Maude opts for a unique approach by presenting the half quail in its entirety. Diners are encouraged to engage with the dish by using their hands to dissect and savor the wings and legs. The chef's mastery in French cuisine shines through as well. Surrounding the quail are classic French meat course accompaniments, spanning from the timeless red wine sauce to the Soubise sauce crafted with onion and cream. Additionally, the grilled, charred yet irresistibly sweet and tender Hawaiian Maui onion echoes harmoniously with the flavors of the bird. Notably, the red wine sauce incorporates a meticulous addition of achiote paste, imparting an earthy and nutty profile on the palate with a subtle hint of spiciness—a final touch of Mexican wildness gracefully woven into the culinary scene.





2013 Soliste, “Out of the Shadows,” Syrah, Bennett Valley, California

Aging: Aged 33-34 months in 450 Liter Barriques

Vinification: 50% Whole Cluster

Harvest Date: 9/27/13

Production: 247 Cases Produced

Vineyard Exposure: West

Vineyard Soil: Gravel

Wine and gastronomy share an inseparable connection, making it truly special to witness an individual who embodies both roles as a chef and a winemaker. Claude Koeberle is precisely such a figure. Once renowned as an exceptional chef, having apprenticed under Paul Bocuse and Alain Chapel and earned the distinction of being the youngest three-Michelin-star Chef in Paris, he founded Soliste in 2005. With the goal of bringing his Burgundian heritage to California, Koeberle aspires to recreate the Burgundian style of wine. In Burgundy, winemakers often set aside a barrel for their family and friends, naming it a special Soliste barrel. Koeberle's specific aim is to encapsulate this feeling of intimacy in his wines, sharing the same high-quality experience with his wine drinkers as he would reserve for his family. This concept also harmonizes with Maude's commitment to offering a homely atmosphere for guests.

Although this Syrah wine signifies that what we are drinking has little to do with Burgundy, there seems to be no better choice to pair with grilled quail than Syrah. The robust tannins, firm acidity, and full-bodied richness of Syrah make it an unparalleled companion to complement the gamey flavor of quail. The intense black fruit flavors, blended with an unctuous aroma, enhanced by the exotic wildness of licorice and peppercorn, give this wine a profound and bold personality. Upon sipping, the tight tannins instantly envelop the palate, creating an exquisite mouthfeel with the quail. These tannins are not astringent; instead, they possess a refined gripping sensation in the mouth, a result of its thirty-three months of aging that tamed it into a gentleman.



Following the main course, a delightful offering featuring blue cheese arrives before us. Maude adeptly redefines the concept of a cheese course. While many restaurants include cheese in the dessert session, at Maude, it acts as a bridge, seamlessly connecting the savory and sweet courses. Yet, it distinguishes itself from the palate cleansers found in other establishments; to me, it resembles more of a laid-back snack enjoyed after the main course. Once again, we enjoy the privilege of witnessing the birth of this course. Presented right before our eyes, the chef takes out the Buñuelo doughnut from the oven, fresh and warm. Two piping bags of honey and blue cheese stand by, ready to fill the Buñuelo doughnut. The doughnut then goes through a snowy landscape of shredded macadamia. The blue cheese, generously mixed with honey, tastes less pungent but more like mascarpone, while the macadamia introduces another layer of nuttiness to balance out the cheesy flavor. This creation is incredibly versatile, making it suitable even for those who dislike cheese, although it could be perceived as too mild for cheese enthusiasts as the cheese no longer takes center stage here.



2021 J. Lohr, Late Harvest Riesling, Arroyo Seco, Monterey, California

Harvest Time: the morning of December 10th

Harvest Sugar Level: 31.5° Brix (357.3g/L)

Harvest Process: Hand-harvested into small bins,
destemmed 50%, held overnight, pressed to taste

Style: Botrytis late harvest wine

Acidity: pH 3.4

Residual Sugar: 97g/L

Production: 354 cases

Fermentation: In 55-gallon stainless steel barrels for 4 months

At times, a glass of wine requires minimal elaboration; its inherent sweetness offers a straightforward and carefree enjoyment. The 2021 J. Lohr Late Harvest Riesling from Arroyo Seco perfectly embodies this concept. This wine is sweet and invigorating, showcasing delightful notes of golden raisin, honey, and marmalade—the distinctive botrytis style sweetness—accentuated by a subtle undertone of white peach and white tea. The palate is uncomplicated, featuring a balanced acidity that prevents the overall bottle from becoming overly sweet. Notably high in sweetness, the grape sweetness at harvest aligns with the highest level in the German Prädikatswein classification. According to Kristen Barnhisel, the winemaker at J. Lohr Winery, this wine is "reminiscent of the great Trockenbeerenauslese wines of Germany." However, it is evident that various aspects of this wine still fall short of the remarkable Trockenbeerenauslese wines of Germany. In terms of pairing, unfortunately, the cheese flavor in this paired dish has been subdued significantly, blending with such a robust honey presence. Therefore, perhaps a glass of German Kabinett wine would suffice for pairing with this cheese dish. That being said, this wine remains delightful on its own. While it might be overly sweet when paired with desserts, it can be a suitable choice alongside a traditional cheese plate.



Completing the cheese course at Maude signifies our shift to the next spot for dessert. It's not just another room; instead, it's a wine cellar with a different door number. We step out of the restaurant, guided by a server holding an umbrella, and make our way to the adjacent building. Climbing a narrow staircase, we enter Maude's wine cellar. While the decor of the adjacent building, with its budget office ambiance, slightly interrupts the mood set by our dinner, the instant we step into the wine cellar, the warm, familial atmosphere envelops us once again. Countless times, I've been taken on tours of restaurant kitchens and wine cellars, times like visiting the luxurious wine cellar at Alain Ducasse in Macau which still leaves a lasting impression. Yet, enjoying desserts exclusively in a wine cellar is a first for me. We are comfortably seated by the piano, and given the cellar's naturally cool temperature, the restaurant considerably provides blankets to ward off the chill. As I gaze upon the array of familiar fine wines beside me, including the Chateau d'Yquem, La Tache, and Comte Georges de Vogue Musigny that I once owned, a sense of ecstasy fills my heart, and without further wait our dessert tasting commences.

The first dish arrives as a palate cleanser, featuring puréed and segmented Hachiya persimmon spiced with housemade chili. This creation is complemented by Moroccan mint and finger lime. The spiced persimmon draws obvious inspiration from the renowned Mango con Chile, a street food deeply rooted in Mexican snacking tradition. Hachiya persimmon, only consumable when fully ripened, unfolds a rich sweet flavor profile with notes of brown sugar, honey, apricots, and raisins. It is flamboyant and possesses depth. While the chili might be intense for those unfamiliar with Mexican fruit culture, the Moroccan mint and finger lime step in to rescue the overwhelmed palate, offering a sharp acidity and a refreshing herbal breeze.



Following the palate cleanser is a dessert that pays homage to the musquée de Provence pumpkin. This unique variety stands out as one of the few squashes that can be enjoyed raw, offering a delightful flavor reminiscent of nutmeg—sweet yet slightly spicy. At the forefront of the presentation is a mini simulated pumpkin crafted with piloncillo sugar (unrefined whole cane sugar), white chocolate ganache, and a caramelized pumpkin core. Encircling the pumpkin is caramelized milk gelato, a maple leaf crafted from pumpkin, and a bed of soil created with pumpkin seed oil. The soil represents a unique instance of applying true molecular gastronomy in tonight's dinner. I suspect that maltodextrin is employed here to transform pumpkin seed oil into powder using a spherification process. When maltodextrin comes into contact with substances high in fat, it reacts with the oil or fat, forming semi-solid spheres with thin membranes out of the fat molecules, resulting in powders. However, these powders dissolve upon encountering liquid, in this case, within the guest's mouth.



2018 Dashe, “Lily Hill Vineyard,” Late Harvest Zinfandel, Dry Creek Valley, California

Vintage: 2018

Varietal: Zinfandel

Appellation: Dry Creek Valley

Vineyard: Lily Hill Vineyard

Sugar: 9.0% by Volume

Aging Oak: 100% French; no new oak

Alcohol: 15.5%

Harvest Date: October 30th

Harvest Sugar Level: 40° Brix

Production: 381 cases

The first dessert wine, paired with the palate cleanser, presents a sophisticated array of aromas and flavors. Crafted from late-harvest Zinfandel grapes cultivated in the Lily Hill Vineyard, this dessert wine reveals the intricate layers of a dark fruit core and warm chocolaty depth, reminding me of a young tawny port. The nose is lush with enticing notes of dried raisin, pomegranate, and smoky cocoa. On the palate, a harmonious continuation of the flavor profile emerges, accompanied by subtle hints of chocolate and vanilla. Unlike a tawny port, it is not viscous, rather, it reveals a crispy and clean finish alongside a sweet-spicy note. The wine also carries a beautiful and firm acidity, making the wine well-balanced. When enjoyed with the dessert, the beautiful flavor profile seamlessly complements the luscious persimmon and chili spice, creating a delightful sensory experience.



After the microscopic molecular-level spheres, here comes a tangible sphere, in the form as a sugar dome encapsulating cocoa nibs, mole espuma, corico sinaloense cookie made with corn flour, apple purée, and salted caramel. The sphere rests on a soft bed of almond sponge cake embedded with salted-caramelized apple. Although officially titled Windrose Farm Arkansas Black Apples, it remains unclear on the palate whether the apple is the central ingredient. On the contrary, the dark notes of mole, caramel, and cocoa appear more dominant. Regardless of its title, this dessert seems like another celebration of key elements in Mexican cuisine, specifically the mole sauce. It's a bold move to transform a savory ingredient into a dessert.

Overall, the dessert feels overpowering. The sphere contains numerous robust flavors, and although the ingredients seem to align in flavor, their distinct textures prevent a harmonious blend. Furthermore, the sugar sphere, with its excessive hardness and thickness, not only stands apart but also introduces a flavor that disrupts the overall expression of the other key ingredients.



To conclude the dinner, three delightful mignardise await. We begin with a bonbon crafted from dark chocolate and morita chili, imparting subtle hints of spiciness. It seems the chef won't miss any opportunity to showcase his chili culture, even in the final petit fours. But it must be admitted that chili and chocolate coexist harmoniously and are not uncommon in everyday life. Following is an exceptional macaron, skillfully blending the flavors of sesame and guava. Although these two ingredients are not commonly paired, their combination creates a delightful duet within the petite pastry. Ultimately, the tasting experience culminates with a crème puff that masterfully highlights the opulence of Medjool dates. While some approaches in the dessert section may be open to discussion, overall, it once again showcases the passion of Maude restaurant. Bold, and full of vitality.



**2018 Babcock Winery, “Once in a Lifetime,”
Ultra Late Harvest Viognier,
Santa Barbara County, California**

Vineyard: Bien Nacido Vineyard
Appellation: Santa Maria Valley AVA

Style: Botrytis ultra late harvest wine
Harvest Sugar Level: 40° Brix (470.7g/L)
Result Sugar Level: 22° Brix (239.8g/L)
Antonio Galloni: 95/100
Matt Kettmann (WE): 93/100

Earning an exceptional 95 points from Antonio Galloni, the ensuing dessert wine lives up to its name—truly a once-in-a-lifetime experience. Crafted from ultra late harvest Viognier grapes, this bottle is produced from grapes harvested at an astonishing sugar level of up to 40 Brix, surpassing even the German Trockenbeerenauslese. The influence of Botrytis imparts a captivating sweetness that is both bold and concentrated, yet remarkably refreshing. Pouring into the glass with a radiant golden hue, the wine transports the drinker to a luscious summer scene on the sun-drenched Sicilian island. Its honey floral and tropical fruit core, complemented by notes of powdery white flowers, honeycomb, almost overripe Roman cantaloupe, kumquat, and mango, contribute to the indulgent viscosity of this nectar. Undoubtedly, one of the most opulent dessert wines I've ever encountered.



2015 Château Soucherie, Premier Cru Chaume, Coteaux du Layon

Composition: 100% Chenin Blanc

Appellation: Coteaux du Layon, Loire Valley

Style: Botrytis Wine

Residual Sugar: 140 g/l

Soil Composition: Clay and schist

Viticulture: 60-year-old vines

Vinification: The wine is fermented in barrel, 50% is new,
and then spends 18 months in barrel for the élevage.

Unexpectedly joining the Babcock ultra late harvest Viognier is an exquisite 2015 Chenin Blanc sweet wine from Chateau Soucherie. This delightful addition seems to be a gracious reward from the sommelier, perhaps a nod to my evident passion for wine, and possibly fueled by me being the first to recognize the Sauternes glass earlier in the evening.

While the theme of the wine pairing journey revolves around selections from the west coast of the United States, this particular gem, featured in the premier international wine pairing menu, hails from the Coteaux du Layon 1er cru Chaume in the Loire Valley. The Vallée du Layon's climate provides an ideal environment for the cultivation of botrytis cinerea, renowned as the noble rot. Cool, damp nights, morning dew, and fog, interspersed with warm, sunlit afternoons, contribute to the controlled growth of these beneficial fungi, imparting a unique character to the wines produced in this region.

Interestingly, in 2003, when the Institut national de l'origine et de la qualité bestowed its own AOC upon Chaume, naming it Chaume Premier Cru des Coteaux du Layon, uproars emerged among other Loire producers. The adoption of the premier cru nomenclature, more reminiscent of Burgundian traditions than those of the Loire, stirred some controversy. Nonetheless, the designation stands as a testament to the region's esteemed reputation for producing high-quality wines.

Sampled alongside the Babcock ultra late harvest Viognier, this Chenin Blanc unveils itself as markedly purer, more elegant, and refined. While Babcock pursues the creation of a wine of ultimate lushness, this French counterpart strives to present the world with an elegant, refreshing, linear, and gracefully sweet offering. This fine nectar exhibits enchanting notes of honey, quince, apricot, and young opal apple, enhanced by intriguing hints of chamomile, baked cookie, and a delicate floral and rice medley reminiscent of a fine sake.



Embarking on the culinary journey at Maude is a truly exceptional experience, where every element, from the exhilarating flavors of the food to the enchanting wine pairings, and the warm ambiance to the passionate service, contributes to an unforgettable dining adventure.

The most impressive aspect of Maude's culinary prowess is its mastery of chili peppers. Throughout the thirteen-course meal, we encounter an impressive eleven instances of various chili and hot sauce applications. Whether incorporating the most traditional Mexican hot sauce directly, blending it into a classic French red wine sauce, or playfully mixing it with Japanese sauces, Maude's approach is a boundary-free exploration, skillfully executed and infused with intrigue. Each dish prompts spontaneous exclamations like, "Wow! Can it be done like this? It's magical!" Maude's commitment to pushing the boundaries of each dish garners admiration from diners of all backgrounds.

Reflecting on the meal, I've gained a deeper appreciation for why some restaurants transcend the pursuit of mere deliciousness. Tastiness is an exclamation driven by a primitive biological instinct. It can be triggered by a brilliantly crafted foie gras dish just as easily as by a casual taco bought on the street. However, the true essence of fine dining, as exemplified by Maude, lies in the meticulous design of dishes, the thoughtful pairing and balance of ingredients, the inventive use of unconventional elements, and their seamless integration across diverse culinary traditions. This is the gastronomic obligation in a world where basic sustenance is no longer a primary concern.



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